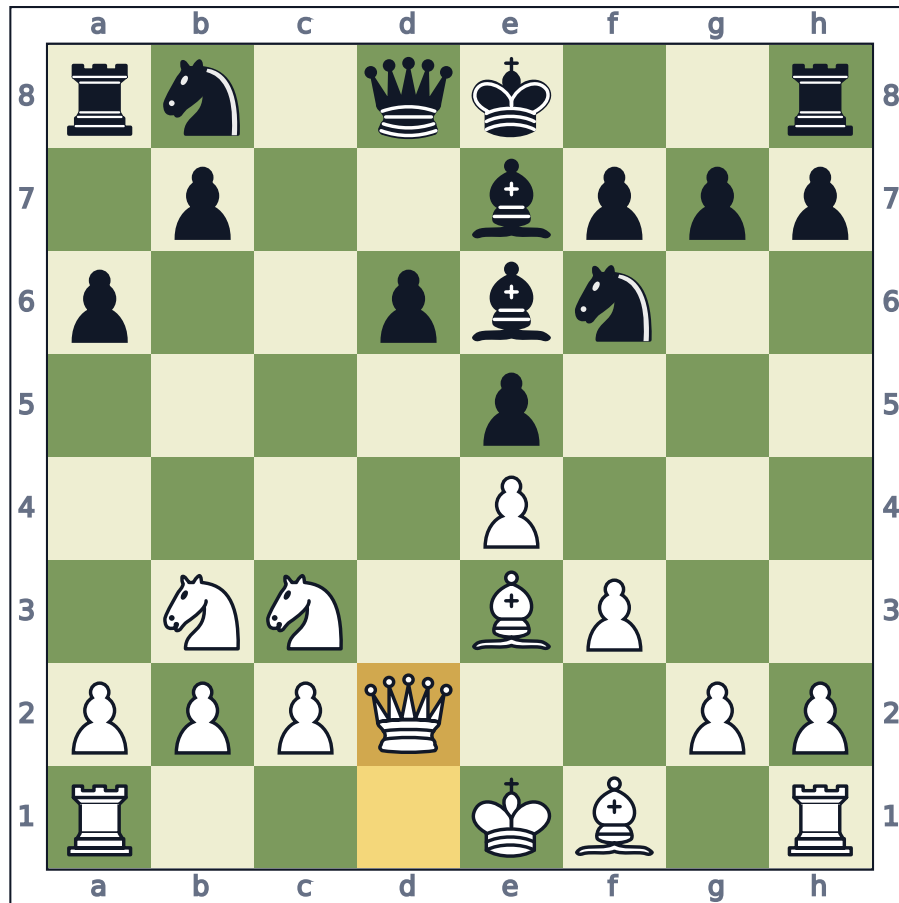


Sicilian Najdorf

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

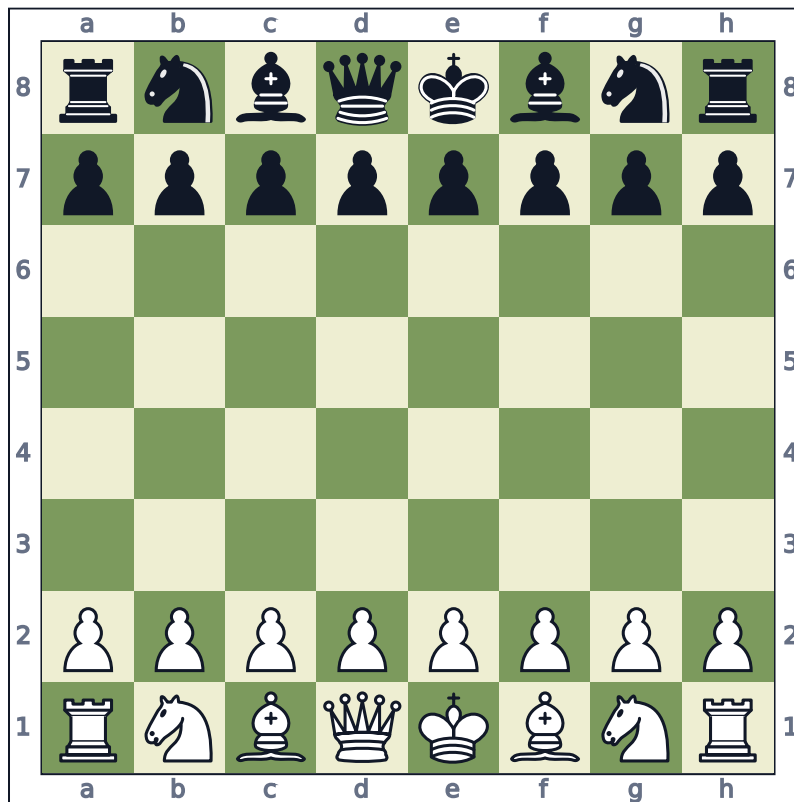
OPENING IDENTITY

Black's ...a6 controls b5 and prepares flexible queenside expansion.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

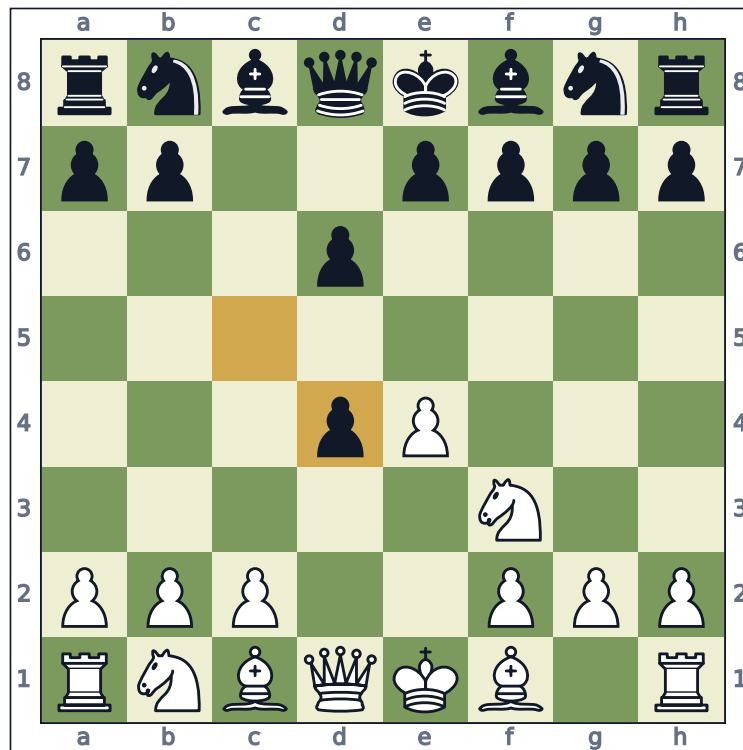
1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4

Course promise: Control b5, expand with ...b5, fight for d5.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4



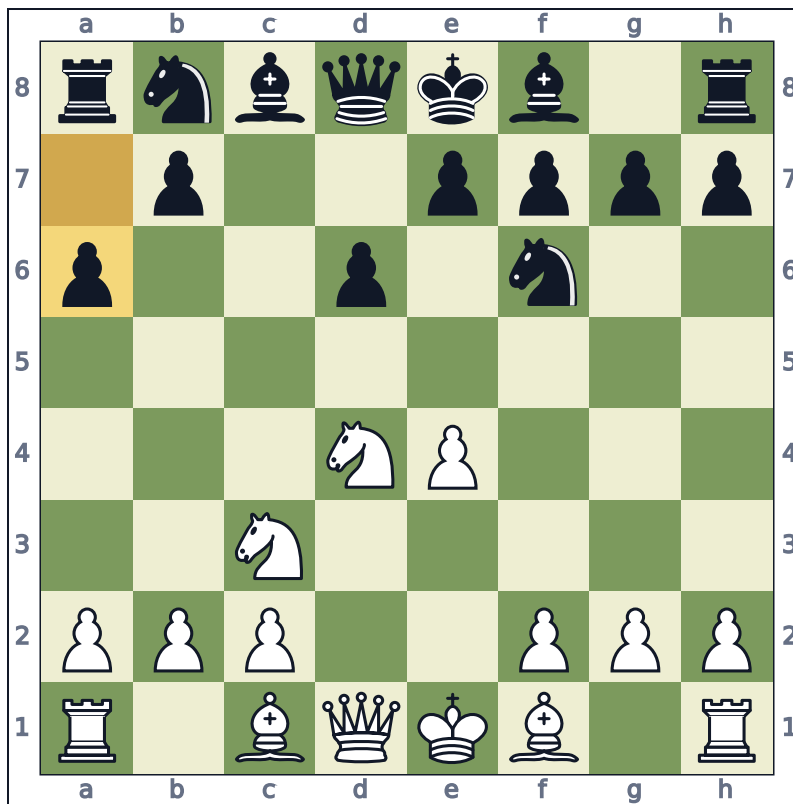
After 3. d4 cxd4

- 1. e4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... c5 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2. Nf3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 2... d6 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 3. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 3... cxd4 - Resolves central tension and changes the pawn structure.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black's ...a6 controls b5 and prepares flexible queenside expansion.

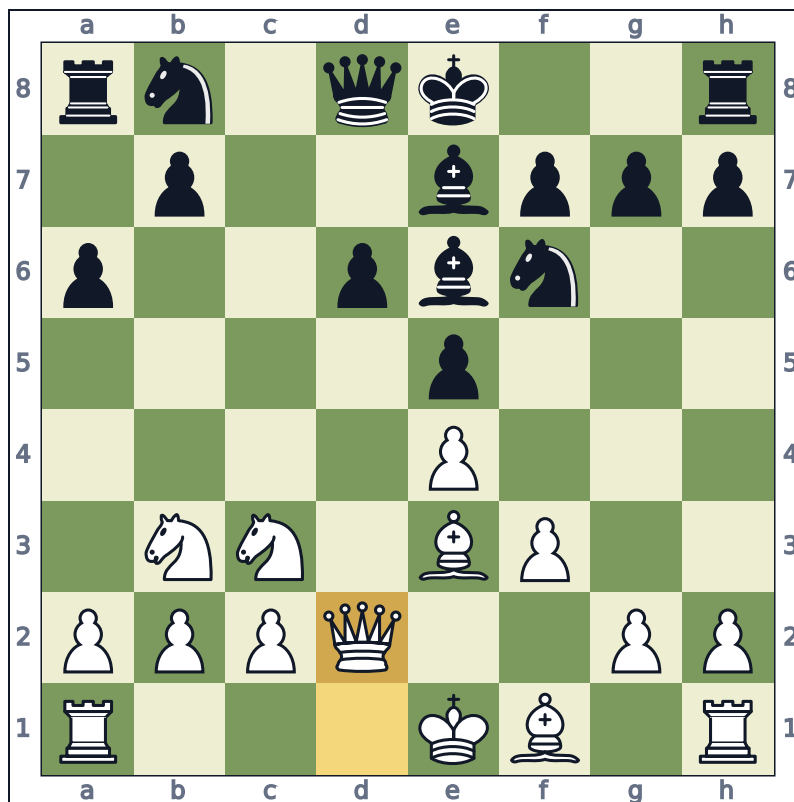
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. f3 Be7 9. Qd2



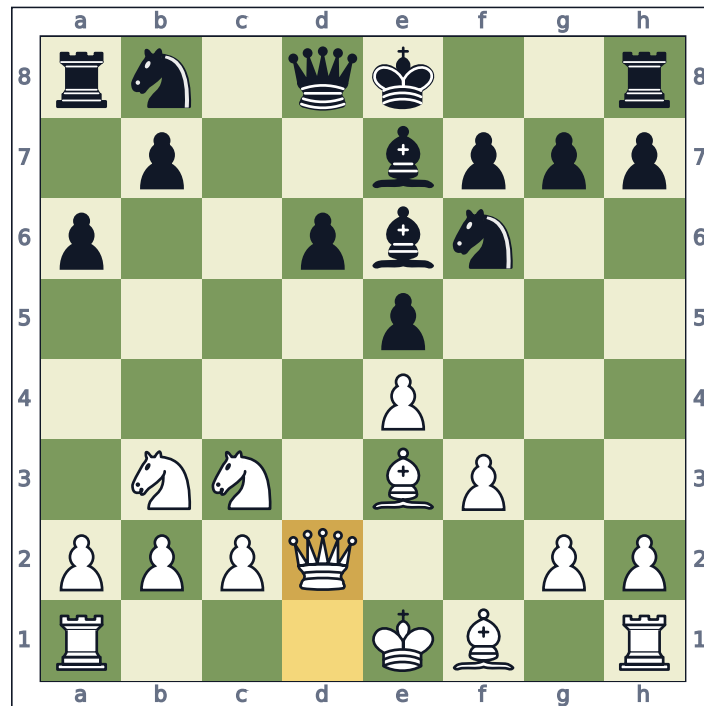
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black's ...a6 controls b5 and prepares flexible queenside expansion. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Choose a clear setup, finish queenside development, and attack before Black completes counterplay.

BLACK'S PLAN

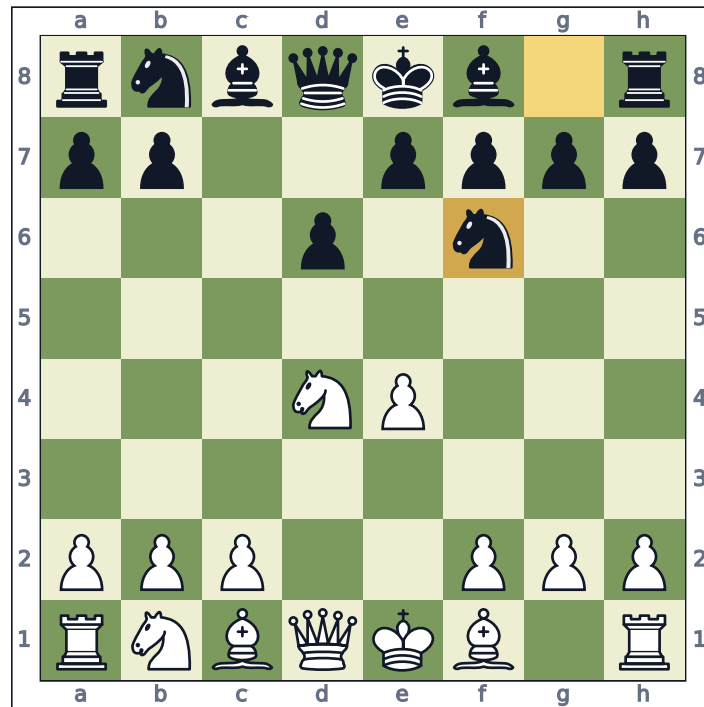
Use ...b5, pressure the center, and pick ...e5 or ...e6 according to White's setup.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...b5-b4 is thematic; White often uses g4-g5 or f4-f5.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - White to move

THEME

The d5-square and d6-pawn are strategic targets, but grabbing them prematurely can lose time.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

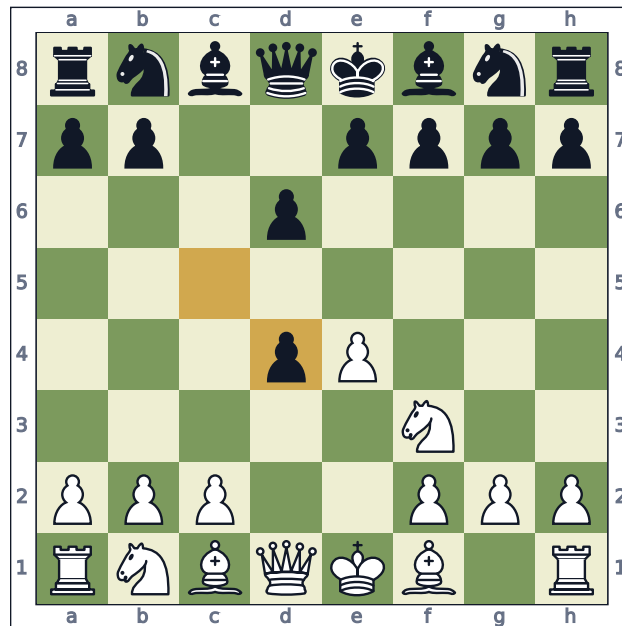
Memorizing sharp moves without understanding why ...a6 changes b5.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black's ...a6 controls b5 and prepares flexible queenside expansion.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...b5-b4 is thematic; White often uses g4-g5 or f4-f5.

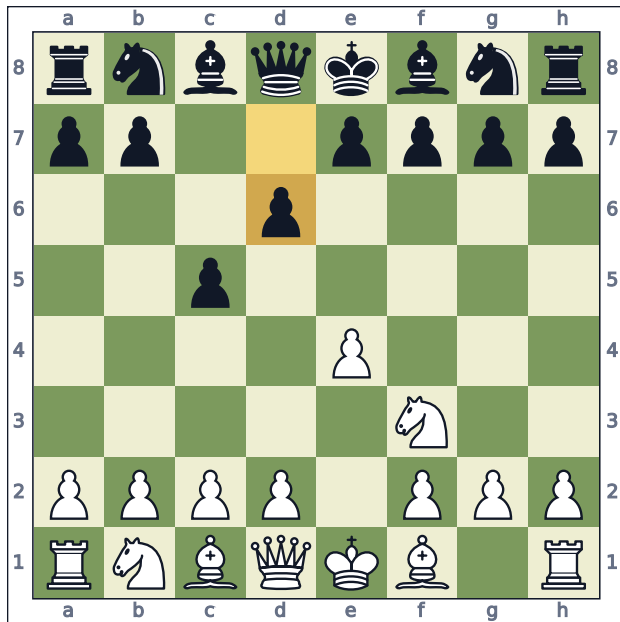
MEMORY SENTENCE

Control b5, expand with ...b5, fight for d5.

ACTIVE RECALL

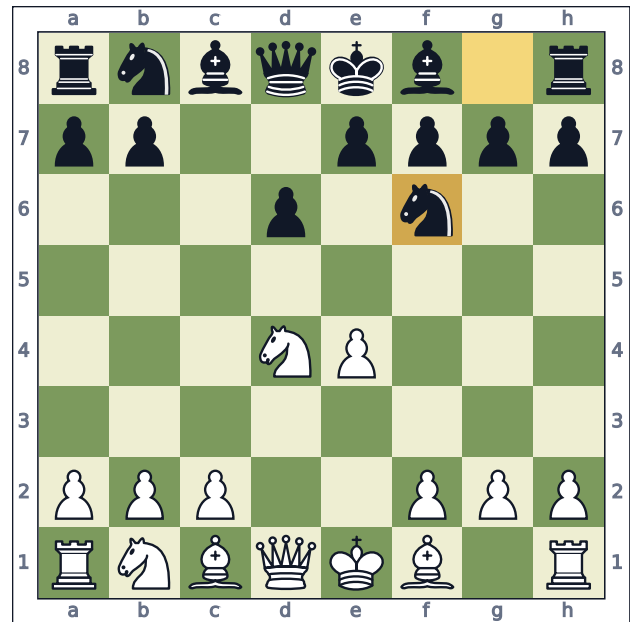
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: d4. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: Nc3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Choose a clear setup, finish queenside development, and attack before Black completes counterplay.

Black: Use ...b5, pressure the center, and pick ...e5 or ...e6 according to White's setup. Lever: ...b5-b4 is thematic; White often uses g4-g5 or f4-f5.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.